

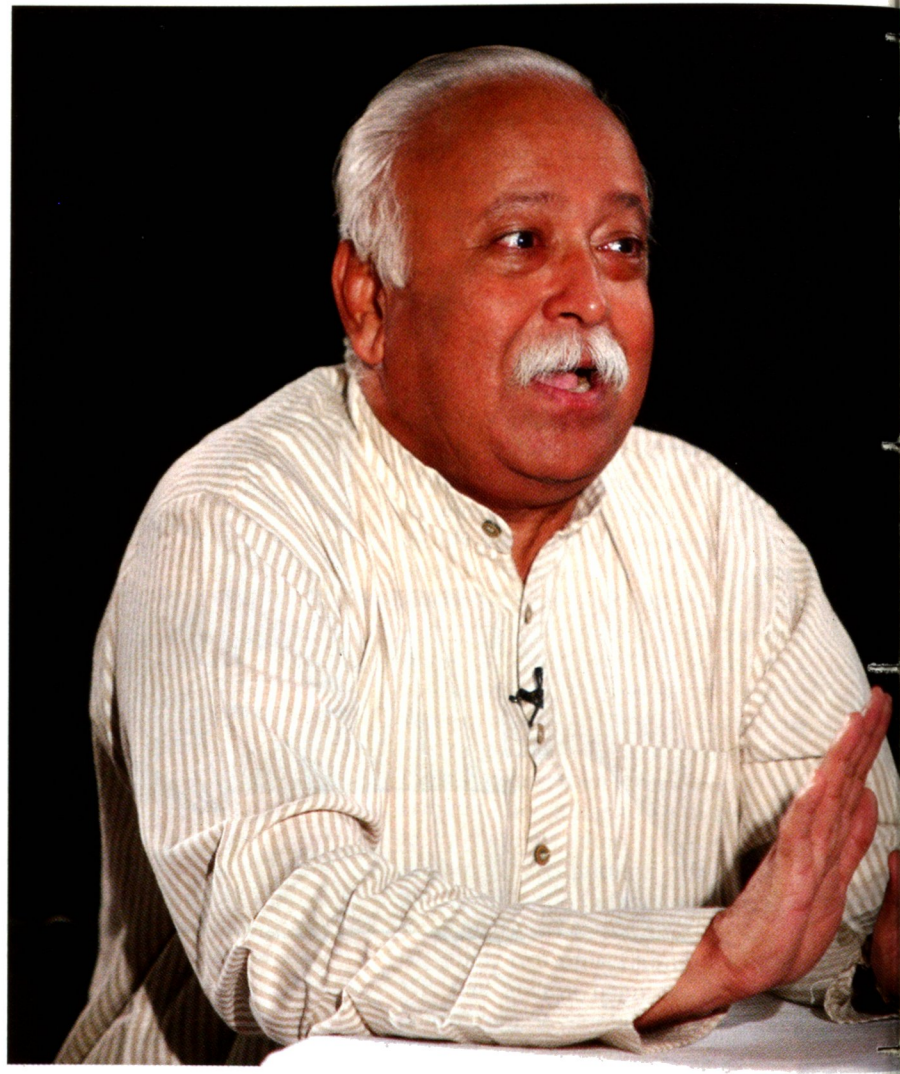
At a time when the BJP is going through its worst existential crisis, the man with the walrus moustache and a mischievous glint in his eyes has become the most sought-after oracle in town. Mohanrao Bhagwat, the 59-year-old boss of the RSS, plays the role to perfection, and every word of his continues to be worthy of Page 1 nowadays. The media savvy Bhagwat's ascension as the head of the House of Saffron has marked a generational as well as cultural shift in the organisation. He is the moderniser, the 21st century face of the RSS. As the BJP seems to have abandoned its core ideology for the sake of coalition politics, Bhagwat has brought Hindutva back to the national agenda. As the BJP suffers from the absence of a leader who can take the party out of the wreckage of defeat, the sixth sarsangh-chalak has become the supreme guide and the wise counsellor. As the party retreats from the national mindspace, he styles himself as the last apostle of the nationalist cause. As its ambitious but discredited leaders struggle for the spoils of a lost war, he tells them: behave or be damned. Still, the Brahmin bachelor from Chandrapur in Maharashtra finds time to read the new Dan Brown. Like the symbolist hero in *The Lost Symbol*, Bhagwat too has to think smart and act fast to save the Parivar he heads. In a candid conversation with Editor PRABHU CHAWLA for the Seedhi Baat show on Aaj Tak channel at the RSS office in Jhandewalan in Delhi, Bhagwat talks about subjects ranging from the future leadership of the BJP to Vande Mataram, from Chidambaram to Modi, from Pakistan to China—and more. Excerpts.

Q. What do you think about the Deoband reaction against Vande Mataram?

A. Vande Mataram is for all Indians. It was part of our freedom movement and history. There was a time when both Hindus and Muslims sang it.

Q. The Muslims say it is against their religion.

A. I don't think any religion is against *desh bhakti*. To say *Bharat Mata ki Jai* and Vande Mataram is not like a religious *pooja* or idol worship.



“Everyone in India will have to say Vande Mataram. It is for all Indians and was a part of our freedom movement and history.”

Q. What is the Sangh's view?

A. (Thumps the table) Vande Mataram *kehna hoga* (Everyone in India will have to say Vande Mataram).

Q. Do you think the minorities felt threatened after the Masjid fell?

A. I would say that the wishes of the Hindu *samaj* were ignored by the gov-

ernment. The anger against the system was taken out on the structure.

Q. But your strong take on the Babri Masjid, the Uniform Civil Code and Article 370 makes minorities insecure.

A. Just tell me why is there no rational dialogue regarding such matters. For 90 years there has been no court judgement (on the Ram Mandir). And when nothing happens, the average man loses his balance.

Q. V.P. Singh had a formula to build both *mandir* and *masjid* at Ayodhya. As a responsible organisation why don't you show some magnanimity?

A. This will not create unity. If a Ram Mandir is built peacefully, it will